staggering 143 of the top 50, more than the next two cities combined.

4 But the South is the country's quiet powerhouse. Bengaluru and Chennai together claim 34 top-10 placements, with Bengaluru's CHRIST, Kristu Jayanti and St Joseph's colleges pushing into territory once occupied by legacy names.

5 Bengaluru is the education capital of the new India. If Delhi owns the legacy crown, Bengaluru owns the emerging one: it tops the emerging-college lists in stream after stream.

6 There is a best city for almost every course. The survey breaks the country down by stream: Bengaluru for BBA and BCA, Mumbai for Commerce, Chennai and Coimbatore for Science and Social Work, Mangaluru for Dental, Pune for Law and Hotel Management.

7 Great education need not be expensive. The lowest full-course Arts and Commerce fee in the survey is Rs 959, at A.P.C. Mahalaxmi College for Women in Thoothukudi, Tamil Nadu. Several top-quality colleges charge less for three years than a single month's coaching in a metro.

8 There's an enormous gap between fees at private and government colleges. A government engineering seat at Zakir Husain College in Aligarh costs Rs 43,633 for the whole course while private engineering fees run into several lakhs.

9 Return on investment (RoI) is now a ranking in itself. Among the survey's most practical innovations. It divides average salary by total course fee to score value for money. Sydenham College of Commerce in Mumbai tops Commerce RoI at 26.75.

10 The highest salary isn't always the best deal. IIIT Hyderabad records the survey's top private-engineering package at Rs 37.4 lakh, yet a modestly priced TKM College of Engineering in Kollam beats it on pure RoI.

11 The cheapest college and the costliest can both be 'best value'. RoI scoring means a Rs 959 arts degree and a multi-lakh engineering programme can each top their value tables.

12 Government colleges still offer the best value in engineering. Be it IIT Delhi, DTU or Aligarh's Zakir Husain College, government engineering institutions deliver higher RoI than private ones.

13 Placement records are reported, not assumed. Lady Shri Ram leads Commerce placements at an average Rs 11.9 lakh, IIT Delhi tops government engineering at Rs 27.8 lakh. These are college-submitted, verified figures, a reality check against glossy brochures.

14 We kept adding disciplines until the survey covered how India actually studies. From a handful of streams at the start, the ranking now spans 14. Dental and Architecture were added as India's aspirations diversified.

15 We split government and private engineering colleges for fair comparison. An IIT funded by the state and a self-financed private institute are not playing the same game. Ranking them separately means a parent can compare like with like—IIT Delhi against IIT Kanpur, BITS Pilani against IIIT Hyderabad.

16 We started ranking subjects, not just colleges. Since 2023, the survey ranks individual subjects—Physics, Chemistry, Economics, History, English, Psychology, Political Science, Sociology etc. A student who wants Economics can find that Hindu College leads it, even where the order shifts subject by subject.

17 We created 'Emerging Colleges', so that young institutions get a fair hearing. Colleges set up in or after 2000 are judged against each other, not against century-old legacies. That is how names like Kristu Jayanti surface.

18 We track movement every year and crown the biggest gainers. The survey doesn't just photograph the present, it watches the trajectory. NIT Meghalaya jumped 11 places

EMERGING COLLEGE DESTINATIONS

Small towns whose colleges have broken into the top 30

STREAM	CITY	NO. OF COLLEGES
ARCHITECTURE	LUCKNOW	2
BBA	COIMBATORE & JAIPUR	1 each
BCA	PUNE	2
COMMERCE	CHANDIGARH	1
DENTAL	MANGALURU	3
ENGINEERING	PUNE	2
FASHION DESIGN	PUNE	2
HOTEL MANAGEMENT	PUNE	2
LAW	PUNE	3
MASS COMMUNICATION	KOTTAYAM	2
MEDICAL	LUDHIANA	2
SCIENCE	KOCHI	1
SOCIAL WORK	COIMBATORE	4